

THE ENLIGHTENED WILL: BALANCING DETACHMENT AND ACTION

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The Will forces are essential for human life - they are what allow us to take action and engage fully with life.

However the path of spiritual development relies on a type of detachment, in which we do not identify our true self with the personality of our present lifetime.

Detachment also manifests in not being emotionally attached or dependent on specific outcomes in life; to not have wild swings between elation over having desires fulfilled or massive depression when desires are crushed and denied (this swing is well known today in psychology as manic-depression, however every human being is subject to this swing to some extent unless they are very spiritually advanced).

This detachment, if developed by itself, can easily lead to no longer fully exercising our will power in the world, to instead become a renunciate -- at its most extreme, to turn away from human incarnation entirely, focus only on the Divine and cease taking action / generating karma in the physical world.

The Key Spiritual Lesson here, known to all great traditions, is that we have to develop and hold in balance the two complementary aspects of Detachment and Action in the World at the same time (balancing two complementary aspects is a general principle which manifests in many ways in Initiation, although we are only concerned with its manifestation here regarding Detachment and Will).

By developing true Detachment, we are no longer the slave of pain and pleasure, extremes of joy and sorrow, based on what life does or does not bring to us. We become the Master of our internal life and consciousness (the true meaning of a Spiritual "Master.") This must be accompanied by full development of the Will power, of self-willed Action in the world.

These two come together to form a synthesis, which may be called "Detached Action" or "Detached Dynamism." This is the lesson of the Bhagavad Gita, where Krishna teaches Arjuna that he must act with total energy and commitment to protect the Dharma, but with no attachment to the final outcome; simply doing the One Right Action in

the moment. This is taught in the Christian tradition within the saying of Christ to “Be IN the World, but not OF It.”

Every major tradition engages with this core truth of human existence. Just a few examples:

On the Rosicrucian Path this is expressed in the principle of “All Knowledge and Powers Gained on the Path will be put to the Service of Others.”

In Buddhism this is the Bodhisattva Vow: to pledge to continue to reincarnate on Earth and dedicate oneself to the Service of Others, until all Sentient Beings attain Enlightenment.

In Hinduism this is service to the Dharma; the Kshatriya (warrior) caste pledges their lives to defend the Dharma. The great text of the Sanatana Dharma in the Indian tradition is the Bhagavad Gita, in which Arjuna is schooled by Krishna in the principles of becoming a Dharma Warrior.

In Japanese tradition, the core principle is honour and “Giri”, which is to unfailingly perform one’s duty regardless of the cost. Giri is sometimes referred to as the “Burden hardest to Bear.”

In the Western tradition, many of the advanced Initiates (sometimes referred to as “Masters” in groups like the Theosophists) are known to have had multiple lifetimes where they were martyred -- tortured and killed -- for serving spiritual causes against oppressive authorities. This is because at higher levels of developing Spiritual Consciousness, it becomes clear there is a specific Right Action in any given situation.

The difference between the ordinary person and the high Initiate is that the ordinary person wavers with a dualistic mind that thinks about the possible suffering that will come from taking that one right action, whereas the Initiate with a unified mind does just that one right thing without internal resistance.

On the path of Initiation, we move beyond intellectual concepts about spiritual realities into DIRECT EXPERIENCE of these realities (although we must develop true concepts of spiritual reality on the first steps of the Path, this must become direct perception of, and interaction with, spiritual realities during later steps).

This includes fundamental realizations about our own nature that become conscious and fully integrated into our “I AM” Spirit Core:

- a) The direct experience that our core nature is the same as the Godhead, the ONE which is the unity of all Being.
- b) The fully conscious Re-Membering of who we were in previous lifetimes (called “Reading the Name inscribed on the Stone” in some parts of the Western Tradition) as a context for every aspect of our current Personality, Relationships, and Life Circumstances.
- c) The knowledge that we are immortal Beings, who will Die in our present life only to be Reborn and continue our Path of Initiation. This will lead us to actualizing our unique spiritual Individuality, either more quickly through skilful means and active consciousness development, or over a longer period of time through remaining in ignorance and acting unskilfully until the “School of Hard Knocks” finally wakes us up. With these higher consciousness realizations integrated into our core selves, we then reach the levels of the Initiates who choose the Right Action in any situation, even if it means intense suffering and death in the current lifetime. The Initiate understands that even the worst and most painful death in one lifetime is, in a larger context of repeated Earthly lives, no different than a child going to bed unhappy one night -- they will wake up the next morning, and their life will continue with the previous unhappiness forgotten in time. Initiates also know that taking the Right Action - regardless of consequences -- develops powerful spiritual forces in a person, which greatly accelerates their spiritual development in future incarnations.

Our second essential exercise, then, is the foundation of developing this ability of taking Right Action in our life while remaining Detached from emotional investment in a particular outcome of the Action. We take the action because it is the right thing to do.

The Japanese tradition has a wonderful teaching story, in which a General speaks to an Initiate before a great battle, where life and death hangs in the balance, and the General is caught in his own dualistic mind. He attained enlightenment from the counsel of the Initiate: “Strip Away the Duality, and Leave the One Sword Straight Against the Sky.” There is only one thing to do. Do it with a unified mind and full commitment, with no attachment to outcome.

A NOTE ON RIGHT ACTION:

“Right Action” is one part of the 8-fold Path of Buddhism; these 8 exercises are understood by the Rosicrucians to particularly develop the Throat Chakra. This is related to the principle we described in Class 1 wherein each Chakra has a certain number of Lotus Petals, half of which are already developed and half of which we develop now through Initiation Practices. The Throat Chakra is the 16- petal Lotus, so there are 8 practices which develop the Throat Chakra fully: these are the 8-fold Path of Buddhism, which also appear as 8 exercises in Rosicrucianism. The Throat Chakra, when developed, becomes a new organ of spiritual perception, giving us the power to clairvoyantly perceive the thoughts of other people, and the activities of spiritual beings in creating the “natural laws” that govern the world around us.

We will go into detail about these 8 exercises in a future online Course